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Cross-Cultural Regularities and Variability in the Emotion of Shame

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Abstract

Shame appears to be part of human nature, yet it varies across time and between cultures. While differences in social norms or attributional styles are often cited as driving forces behind variation in shame, these approaches struggles to explain cross-cultural regularities in shame and the tight alignment between the features of the shame system and the challenges it addresses. In this chapter, we characterize shame from an adaptationist perspective—viewing this emotion as an evolved adaptation shaped by natural selection. We argue that despite its diversity of cultural expressions, shame functions to mitigate the actual or potential costs of being devalued by others. This framework can account for both cross-cultural similarities and differences in how shame is felt, expressed, and regulated. What may appear as culturally unique expressions of shame can be understood as variations on a universal theme: a finely tuned system evolved to manage the adverse consequences of devaluation. This approach reveals that even cultural differences in shame stem from a common adaptive logic.

Introduction

What is shame? We believe that a comprehensive answer to this question requires an adaptationist approach (Cosmides & Tooby, 2000; Tooby & Cosmides, 1992; Williams, 1966). On this approach, human nature consists of the design features–adaptations–that arose and were retained over evolutionary time because they reliably improved the probability of reproduction relative to alternative designs (Tooby & Cosmides, 1992, 2015). The goal of the adaptationist program is to reverse engineer adaptations guided by hypotheses about the adaptive problems that shaped their evolution in the ancestral environments (Tooby & Cosmides, 1992). In other words, to grasp how our minds work in the present, it is advantageous to look to the past. In what follows, we describe an adaptationist framework for understanding the emotion of shame.

Evolutionary Origins of Shame

The environments in which our hunter-gatherer ancestors evolved were characterized by resource scarcity, food shortages, diseases, injuries, and high rates of mortality and aggression (Burger & Vaupel, 2012; Hill & Hurtado, 1996; Kaplan & Hill, 1985; Keeley, 1997; Sugiyama, 2004). To merely survive long enough to reproduce–let alone thrive–required the continued assistance of friends, family, allies, mates, and group members (Burkart et al., 2009; Clutton-Brock, 2009; Kaplan et al., 2000; Schrock et al., 2020; Tomasello et al., 2012). Obtaining the necessary help to survive and reproduce would thus have been a problem of great importance for our ancestors. Those who behaved in ways that incentivized others to offer them help would have successfully reproduced more often, leaving behind more copies of their genes (Von Ruden & Jaeggi, 2016).

In humans, decisions to help others (and to help oneself at others' expense) are shaped by information about specific interaction partners. When deciding whether to help a particular person, inviduals weigh the costs they would incur against the benefits to that recipient (Delton & Robertson, 2016; Delton et al., 2023; Lieberman et al., 2007; Sznycer et al., 2019). For instance, would you drive your friend to the airport? Would you give him a kidney? Answering these questions requires mental calculations that rely on various inputs, including cues of genetic relatedness, the other's capacity and willingness to offer benefits to the actor (e.g., food) (Qi & Vul, 2022; Quillien et al., 2023), and the recipient's relative ability to impose costs on the actor through intimidation, among other factors. The mind uses these and similar cues to produce a summary estimate of the social value of another individual to the actor (whether as a sibling, mate, or friend) and determines the weight to place on that person's welfare (i.e., the actor's Welfare Tradeoff Ratio, or WTR, toward individual *i*) when making decisions (Delton et al., 2023; Tooby et al., 2008).

Internal estimates of individuals' social value—both of others to the actor and of the actor to others—play a key role in how goods and bads flow within a group. For instance, researchers have argued that self-esteem serves as a psychological index that tracks one's social inclusion and value within a group (Leary et al., 1995). Such approximations of social value (e.g., perceptions of social status; see Mahadevan, 2018) are used by motivational, emotional, and cognitive systems to shape others' impressions of the self, restore acceptance after exclusion, and manage similar social challenges. When new information about an individual's value emerges—whether positive or negative—people recalibrate their social valuations accordingly. These recalibrations can have sweeping effects on people's well-being, as they dictate others' inclination to attend to, help, support, or, reciprocally, to exclude and exploit them (Tooby et al., 2008).

The Information Threat Theory of Shame

The existence of group members whose psychology inclined them to trade more or less of their personal welfare to enhance (or reduce) the welfare of others would have presented both challenges and opportunities to our ancestors. One challenge lies in the possiblity of exposing negative information about the self, leading others to attach less value to the actor's welfare. Shame appears to be the nature's solution to this problem of information-triggered social devaluation (Gilbert, 1997, 1998; Sznycer, 2010, 2021; Sznycer et al, 2016). According to this information-threat theory of shame, shame functions as an internal alarm system, alerting individuals to the potential social costs of their actions and motivating them to take corrective measures to prevent or mitigate damage to their reputation. For example, if negative information about a person—such as dishonesty, incompetence, or disloyalty—became known, it could lead to reduced cooperation from others, loss of social support, and even punishment or exclusion from the group. Shame, therefore, can be seen as an adaptation designed to curb these negative outcomes by encouraging behaviors (e.g., hiding, atoning, lying) that limit the likelihood of devaluation or reducing its costs.

Importantly, a well-engineered shame system would not only react after devaluation has occured but also act prospectively, helping individuals avoid actions that might lead to devaluation or conceal socially devalued acts, traits, or information (Sznycer et al., 2016; Leary, 2015;

Sommerville et al., 2013; Argaman et al., 2024). Thus, in its anticipatory mode, the shame system estimates the expected devaluation from an audience on a case-by-case basis, balances this against the relevant personal benefits (e.g., the personal benefits derived from stealing), and guides behavior accordingly. On this account, the feeling of anticipatory shame conveys information: It reflects the mind's prediction of the cost the actor will incur from others' devaluation for a given act the actor might take, weighted by the likelihood of devaluation; and decision making is guided (in part) by this cost estimate.

If this theory is correct, we would expect a shame system, honed by evolution over deep time, to be finely tuned to prevent and counteract the threat of social devaluation. As an adaptation evolved to defend against devaluation, shame would be triggered by either the anticipation of devaluation or by cues indicating that devaluation is already occurring. Once triggered, shame would orchestrate psychological and behavioral responses aimed at: (i) discouraging the individual from engaging in actions that would likely lead to more harm from social devaluation than personal benefit; (ii) containing the spread of reputational-harming information about the self; (iii) mitigating the extent and impact of any social devaluation that occurs; and, in cases where devaluation has already occurred, (iv) motivating reparative behaviors aimed at limiting its social costs.

Existing evidence supports the hypothesis that shame functions to guard against information-triggered devaluation. For example, when people face potential devaluation, they often experience emotional pain (McDonald & Leary, 2005; Eisenberger, 2012), avoid behaviors that could worsen their reputations (de Hooge et al., 2008; Fehr & Gächter, 2000), and hide damaging information (Rockenbach & Milinski, 2011; Sznycer et al., 2015). If devaluation does occur, shame leads to withdrawal (Leach & Cedam, 2015), appeasement (Keltner et al., 1997), and apologizing (Schniter et al., 2013). The characteristic nonverbal displays of shame, such as averting one's gaze and tilting the head downward, signal submission and reduce others' willingness to punish the actor (Fessler, 1999; Gilbert, 2000; Weisfeld & Dillon, 2012; Landers & Sznycer, 2022). Additionally, shame can activate physiological responses, such as the release of proinflammatory cytokines, which may help the body prepare for the potential risks of disease and injury associated with social exclusion (Dickerson et al., 2009).

Furthermore, experimental manipulations of both prospective and actual devaluation consistently evoke shame (Smith et al., 2002; Dickerson et al., 2008; Robertson et al., 2018), even when individuals are aware they have done nothing wrong (Robertson et al., 2018). In other words, it is the threat of social devaluation, rather than objective wrongdoing itself, that serves as the primary trigger of shame (Robertson et al., 2018).

Cross-Cultural Regularities in Shame

The information threat theory helps explain shame's sensitivity to context (Al-Shawaf et al., 2019). Since the shame system is tuned to the threat of social devaluation, we should expect for certain behaviors or traits to trigger devaluation only with respect to specific audiences, and thus among specific relationships, individuals, or groups. For instance, refusing to assist a rival might lower one's value in the rival's eyes but not in the eyes of a best friend (Lukaszewski & Roney, 2010; Krems et al. 2023). In contrast, more universally negative traits, like incompetence or dishonesty, can lead to far-reaching reputational harm and elicit shame on a broader scale. A

well-designed shame system, therefore, should account for these dynamics, aiming to minimize the overall costs of devaluation in one's social network (see Baumard & Sperber, 2013; Noë & Hammerstein, 1995; Tooby & Cosmides, 1996).

Recently, Sznycer and colleagues tested the hypothesis of a general match between shame and audience devaluation. In a between-subjects design, they asked participants from the United States, India, and Israel to rate either how much shame they would feel about specific negative traits or behaviors (e.g., stinginess, sexual infidelity, poor marksmanship) or how negatively they would view others for displaying those same traits. Results showed strong correlations between anticipated shame and audience devaluation, both within and across these cultures. These results indicate that the shame system predicts the degree of audience devaluation and responds according to the Goldilocks principle: that is, generating neither too much shame nor too little, but just the right amount—calibrated to match the expected level of audience devaluation. This feature avoids the dual errors of shame over-activation (leading to the under-provision of personal benefits) and shame under-activation (leading to excessive devaluation from others). These results also suggest that, at least for some acts and traits, shame is informed by a database (or grammar) of social values that is shared across cultures (Sznycer et al., 2016, Figure 1A-C). Durkee et al. (2019) reported similar results with data from 14 populations in 5 continents (see also Cohen et al., 2020). Importantly, this effect is unique to shame, as other negative emotions, such as sadness and anxiety, do not show the same pattern of alignment with audience devaluation (Sznycer et al., 2016).

Subsequent replication across 15 traditional small-scale societies worldwide indicated that shame's close alignment with audience devaluation is not unique to industrialized cultures but appears to be a pan-human adaptation. In this set of studies, the intensity of shame corresponded with the level of devaluation reported by both local audiences (e.g., the shame felt by the Shuar from the Ecuadorian Amazon matched the devaluation from their fellow Shuar) and even foreign audiences (e.g., the shame felt by the Shuar from the Ecuadorian Amazon matched the devaluation from Nepalese farmers and nomadic pastoralists from Mongolia) (Sznycer et al., 2018). Notably, three commonly recognized sources of cultural variation—geographic proximity, linguistic similarity, and religious affiliation—did not account for the strength of associations in shame, devaluation, or the relationship between the two between communities. These findings indicate that in performing its universal function, the shame system fills in open parameters with social information (i.e., what is devalued in the local ecology): As a system designed to monitor social feedback, shame motivates individuals to adjust behavior in response to anticipated devaluation across diverse cultural contexts (Sznycer et al., 2018, Figure 1D-R). Prominent theoretical models of culture predict variability in emotional responses, yet (as we see here) empirical evidence often reveals surprising similarities across cultures.

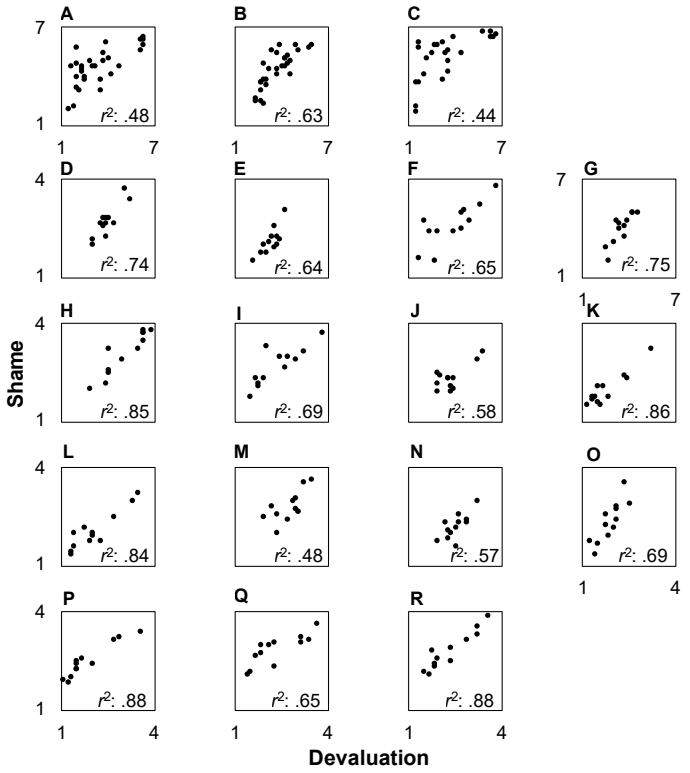


Figure 1. The intensity of anticipatory shame tracks the intensity of audience devaluation. Scatterplots A–C: Data from three mass societies (adapted from Sznycer et al., 2016. Shame closely tracks the threat of devaluation by others, even across cultures. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, 113*(10), 2625–2630). The stimuli were a set of brief hypothetical scenarios describing socially devalued actions and personal characteristics. The scenarios were phrased either from the perspective of the focal individual (e.g. "You are not generous with others"; *shame* condition) or from the perspective of an observer vis-à-vis the focal individual (e.g., "He is not generous with others"; *audience* condition; between-subjects design). For each scenario, participants rated either their feeling of shame if they took those actions or had those characteristics (*shame*), or the degree to which they would negatively view the individual in the scenarios if the individual took those actions or had those characteristics (*audience*). Each point represents the mean shame rating and mean devaluation rating of one scenario. Data from (N of scenarios): A: United States (29); B: India (29); C: Israel (24). Scatterplots D–R: Data from 15 small-scale societies (adapted from Sznycer et al., 2018. Cross-cultural invariances in the architecture of shame. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, 115*(39), 9702–9707). Same experimental design, but with a set of 12 scenarios that were different from the ones used in (Daniel Sznycer et al., 2016). D: Cotopaxi, Ecuador; E: Morona-Santiago, Ecuador; F: Coquimbo, Chile; G: Drâa-Tafilalet, Morocco; H: Enugu, Nigeria; I: Chalkidiki, Greece; J: Ikland, Uganda; K: Le Morne, Mauritius; L: La Gaulette, Mauritius; M: Dhading, Nepal; N: Tuva, Russia; O: Khövsgöl, Mongolia; P: Shaanxi, China; Q: Farming Communities, Japan; R: Fishing Communities, Japan. In all cases, shame ratings and devaluation ratings were given by different participants. Effect sizes: r^2 linear.

Alternative Views on Cultural Differences in Shame

Several psychological and anthropological theories propose that shame operates differently across cultures, reflecting the varied customs, values, and social structures of each society. These perspectives suggest that emotional experiences like shame are socially constructed, emerging within cultural frameworks to maintain social order and regulate behavior (Benedict, 1946; Kitayama et al., 1997; Leung & Cohen, 2011; Shweder, 2003; Wong & Tsai, 2007). On these accounts, while shame may be universally experienced, how it is expressed and regulated varies based on the customs and expectations that structure different social environments. However, we suggest that these cultural variations, too, can be understood through the information threat theory: Different local contexts afford different challenges and opportunities, and the shame system may compute and implement correspondingly different tactics for minimizing the threat of information-triggered devaluation.

Collectivist and Individualist Cultural Differences

A prominent distinction made in cultural psychology is the one between collectivist and individualist societies. In collectivist cultures, such as those found in East Asia, Africa, and Latin America, social harmony and group cohesion are prioritized (Kitayama et al., 1997). The identities of individuals strongly depend on their roles within the group, and maintaining "face" or social standing is crucial. Shame, in these contexts, functions as a powerful tool for aligning individual behavior with communal expectations, deterring actions that would disrupt the social fabric (Hwang, 1987). For example, the public display of shame—as seen in Japan's haji—encourages ritualized acts such as formal apologies and bows, which function to restore social balance and reaffirm commitment to collective values (Benedict, 1946; Hwang, 1987; Ho, 1976). According to the information threat theory, these public acts of contrition may be strategies to signal accountability and reduce the costs of devaluation from group members. Because reputation is embedded in social relationships in collectivist cultures, failing to respond to social missteps could result in widespread social exclusion. Thus, ritualized shame serves as a preemptive defense against further social harm, ensuring that the individual reaffirms their value to others and mitigates reputational losses.

In contrast, individualist cultures such as those in the US and parts of Western Europe tend to emphasize personal achievement, autonomy, and individual responsibility (Markus & Kitayama, 1991). Shame, when experienced in these contexts, is often internalized and managed privately. Public displays of shame in individualist societies can carry different connotations: Instead of signaling accountability, they may be perceived as admissions of failure or incompetence, thereby amplifying social devaluation rather than mitigating it (Tangney & Dearing, 2002).

The information threat theory suggests reasons why the expression of shame varies across collectivist and individualist societies. In highly interconnected, collectivist societies, where people are more likely to know what others have done or where concealing wrongdoing is particularly challenging, displaying shame (more intensely) confers a strategic advantage (see Sznycer et al., 2015). By publicly acknowledging shame, the individual can mitigate the reputational costs that would otherwise result from concealment or denial. The display serves as a signal of submission, dampening potential backlash and signaling a willingness to reintegrate into the group. The consequences of failing to publicly display shame in such cultures are

significant, as shame is deeply tied to maintaining honor not only for the individual but also for their family and close community (Leung & Cohen, 2011).

By contrast, in individualist societies, where social networks are often more fluid and people may have less access to information about others' transgressions, displaying shame publicly can backfire. If others were previously unaware of the wrongdoing, a public display of shame may paradoxically introduce new information that results in further social devaluation. The very act of admitting to a failure or mistake could invite judgments of incompetence, thereby harming the individual's social standing. This dynamic highlights a cost-benefit tradeoff: When the costs from others knowing about one's failure are low and the likelihood of detection is high, public shame displays serve as a functional signal of contrition. But when the cost is high and the likelihood of detection is low, it may be more adaptive to manage shame privately, through self-improvement, enhanced prudence going forward (e.g., concealment), or therapy (Landers & Sznycer, 2022).

These cultural dynamics align with the predictions of the information threat theory. As discussed, the theory suggests that shame is designed to manage the threat of social devaluation by modulating behavior in ways that minimize reputational harm (Landers & Sznycer, 2022; Landers et al., 2024). Therefore, the variability in how shame is expressed across cultures—more publicly in collectivist societies, less publicly individualist ones—may reflect the flexibility of the shame system in responding to different social ecologies. In collectivist societies, the reputational costs of being perceived as unrepentant are particularly steep, so public displays of shame are cost-effective. In individualist societies, where social ties are less binding and reputational threats can be more easily managed through personal means, shame is more likely to be expressed internally. Thus, while the behavioral outputs of shame may differ across cultures, they share a common goal: to mitigate the costs associated with devaluation in a way that is contextually appropriate.

In this way, cultural- or individual-level differences in the expression of shame may not be patterned randomly or contradictorily but instead reflect the operation of open parameters within a shared psychological architecture of shame. This flexibility allows people to navigate the specific challenges posed by their social environments, demonstrating that the expression of shame—whether public or private—remains tied to the problem of minimizing the threat of devaluation.

Honor Cultures and the Role of Reputation

In so-called honor cultures, such as those in the Mediterranean, Middle East, South Asia, and the Southern United States, reputation is paramount; slights to the reputation of the actor or the actor's family are dealt with harshly; and care is correspondingly taken to avoid slighting others (Cohen & Nisbett, 1996; Gambetta, 2009). In cultures of honor, shame is experienced not only as a personal failure but as a collective burden (Leung & Cohen, 2011; Nisbett & Cohen, 1996). Violations of honor—such as public embarrassment or disloyalty—threaten both individual and familial standing. In some cases, restoring honor may involve extreme measures such as revenge or honor-based violence (Gill, 2009; Fiske & Rai, 2014).

From an adaptationist perspective, these behaviors reflect the high stakes of reputation management in honor cultures. Research has shown that intimidation and aggression can serve as cost-effective countermeasures to devaluative threats in certain situations, even though these behaviors are socially undesirable (Leach & Cidam, 2015). On the information threat theory, such extreme responses can be understood as efforts to reestablish social value in contexts in which reputational damage can have especially grave consequences, such as when shame carries collective consequences. Similarly, public acts of revenge or honor restoration serve as costly signals, demonstrating a commitment to protecting social value and deterring future violations (Mosquera et al., 2002).

In East Asian cultures, where shame focuses more on saving face, individuals engage in behaviors designed to avoid public embarrassment and maintain social status (Hwang, 1987; Ho, 1976). This involves not only ritualized apologies but also indirect communication strategies to prevent shame-inducing situations (Nisbett, 2010). These behaviors reflect a preventative approach to shame, ensuring that potential devaluation is avoided before it occurs.
The information threat theory interprets these face-saving practices as proactive efforts to minimize reputational harm. In a high-stakes environment where losing face can jeopardize social inclusion, individuals carefully manage their behavior to signal competence and reliability. The use of indirect communication serves to preserve relationships by reducing the likelihood of confrontation, which could trigger public shame.

Cultural Variation in Shame: Evolved Does not Necessarily Mean Rigid

There are many ways information-triggered devaluation, and the resultant shame, can and do manifest in the world. On the information threat theory, this is because the best responses to minimizing the devaluative threat vary across contexts. For example, if you are doing something that others devalue, and you see that others have witnessed it, you might apologize, make things right, lie about what you were "actually" doing, make excuses, threaten the witnesses (Sznycer & Cohen, 2021), etc. But if you are engaging in the same act, and you know that others have not yet discovered you (e.g., you hear people approaching but know they haven't seen you), the best response might be to stop the act, remove any incriminating evidence, and behave as if nothing happened. In other words, the most cost-effective responses to minimize the costs of devaluation in one context may be less effective or even counterproductive in another. These contingencies may have been coded for by natural selection over deep time, while other, more fine-grained contingencies (e.g., the specific form of an excuse) may be managed through improvisational intelligence (Lukaszewski et al., 2020).

In sum, the argument is that shame is a facultative adaptation—a system governed by universal principles necessary to achieve its core function, but with open parameters that allow it to adjust to specific circumstances (Landers et al., 2024; Landers & Sznycer, 2022; Sznycer et al., 2012; Sznycer et al., 2018). A facultative shame system would dynamically calibrate its outputs to match the actor's perception of the demands of the current environment. This design can explain variability in responses both across situations and, potentially, across cultures. What researchers label as "culture" can be understood, from the adaptation's perspective, as situational inputs—contextual information that guides the individual's behavior in real-time. Thus, while cultures may appear distinct in their expressions of shame, these differences reflect adaptive flexibility rather than rigid cultural rules: The system tailors its responses to the immediate context,

wherever that might be. Thus, an adaptationist perspective on cultural variation in shame overlaps with and complements a cultural psychological perspective, because it leverages the concept of adaptive function to explain and predict cultural differences in shame.

For example, the information threat theory suggests that in social contexts with fewer chances to establish new relationships (i.e., low relational mobility; Yuki et al., 2007), the overall costs of damaging or losing existing relationships are higher because the actor's ability to offset the loss by building new relationships is reduced. Consequently, shame proneness toward current relationship partners, such as friends, should increase as perceived relational mobility decreases. By contrast, individuals with whom one has little or no relationship history, like strangers, are easier to replace, meaning that relational mobility should have little to no effect on shame proneness toward them.

Sznycer and colleagues (2012) tested these predictions. Participants from the US, UK, and Japan reported their tendency to feel shame (their "shame proneness") regarding both a close friend and a stranger, their relational mobility, and the extent to which they possessed valued personal characteristics (e.g., resourcefulness, physical attractiveness).

The results indicated that Japanese participants were more prone to shame compared to their British and American counterparts—aligning with anthropological and cultural-psychological claims that East Asian populations are more shame-prone than, for example, those in the US (e.g., Benedict, 1946). Notably, between populations, lower relational mobility was associated with greater shame proneness toward friends but not toward strangers, and this relationship partially mediated population-level differences in shame proneness. Furthermore, the same relationship between lower relational mobility and greater shame proneness towards friends was also observed within the US and UK (though not in Japan), suggesting that the variables that modulate the operation of shame between situations are the same variables that modulate its operation between cultures. Finally, individuals who reported possessing more valued personal characteristics also reported less shame proneness regarding their close friends.

This work illustrates how the information threat theory of shame—an adaptationist approach—can explain cultural variation (and regularities) in shame: The open parameters of the shame system enable individuals to adapt their responses to their internal and external circumstances, including their personal characteristics and the opportunities to establish new relationships in their local environments.

Social Devaluation, Shame, and the Origins of Criminal Laws

If cultural variation in shame reflects context-specific adjustments within a shared, evolved system designed to manage social devaluation as the information threat theory suggests, then an important implication of this perspective is that patterns of social devaluation and shame will show consistency not only across cultures but also across time (time being another vector, like space, across which cultures may differ).

Recent research by Sznycer and Patrick (2020) provides evidence of trans-historical regularities in social devaluation and its match to shame. In their study, participants from both the United States and India were asked to rate the severity of various offenses drawn from three sets of

statutes: a contemporary criminal code from the United States (a culturally familiar society) and two criminal codes from culturally unfamiliar societies: the Tang Code (China, 653 CE) and the Laws of Eshnunna (Mesopotamia, c. 1770 BCE). Participants were not provided with the legal punishments assigned to these offenses in the original codes; instead, they evaluated the offenses with their intuitions alone: They reported how intensely they would devalue a target individual who commits offense X, how morally wrong they think offense X is, the amount of shame they would feel as perpetrators if they were to commit offense X, and the punishment they propose for offense X in a mock-legal context. To ensure the results reflected intuitive judgments rather than explicit knowledge, participants were removed from analyses if they reported having college training in Law or explicit familiarity with the relevant criminal codes. As might be expected, Sznycer & Patrick observed cross-cultural and historical variation: For example, modern participants rated gratuitously killing one's slave much more severely than Tang lawmakers. Notably, however, the participants' severity ratings (across all the severity measures) closely matched the actual punishments recommended by the legal codes, both ancient and modern. In particular, participants' predictions of how much shame they would feel if they committed these offenses correlated positively with the severity of the corresponding punishments as dictated by modern and ancient lawmakers (Sznycer & Patrick, 2020; see also Wee et al., 2025). The observed combination of similarities and differences across cultures and time periods aligns with the adaptationist perspective, which views the shame system as governed by both universal principles and flexible parameters. While the universal principles account for why participants generally agreed with the Tang lawmakers, the flexible parameters and varying inputs help account for the observed cultural and historical differences. Such studies suggest that social-evaluative psychology may not only underpin shame, but also societal institutions more broadly, such as criminal justice systems.

Alternative Theories of Shame I: Attributional Theories

While the information threat theory views shame as an evolved system designed to limit the adverse consequences of devaluation, other theories conceptualize this emotion differently (Landers et al., 2024). Attributional theories, for instance, focus on shame as part of an inherently intrapersonal process. According to attributional theories, shame arises when individuals interpret events through the lens of personal identity goals—evaluating successes or failures in ways that reflect on who they aspire to be (Lewis, 1971; Tangney, 1990; Tracy & Robins, 2004).

The specific nature of these interpretations or attributions determines which emotion is elicited. For example, failing an exam leads to guilt when people attribute their failure to controllable, unstable causes (e.g., "I didn't study enough"), but failing an exam leads to shame when the people attribute their failure to global, stable, uncontrollable causes (e.g., "I'm unintelligent") (Tangney, 1990; Tracy & Robins, 2004). Attributional researchers have observed that guilt leads to apologies and amends more reliably than shame does, and moreover, that shame but not guilt is associated with evasion and aggression (Tangney et al., 1992; Elison et al., 2014). For this reason, attributional theories construe shame as a maladaptive emotion, an inferior substitute for guilt (Tangney, Wagner, et al., 1996).

By contrast, the information threat theory conceptualizes shame as an adaptation that evolved because it was well-designed to address *inter*personal challenges (Gilbert, 1998; Leary, 2015; Sznycer et al., 2016; see also Fessler, 1999). According to this view, shame responses are

triggered not only by the actor's interpretation of their own failures, but also by how they perceive others might devalue them based on those failures. For example, a student who fails an exam may feel ashamed not only because they interpret the failure as reflecting poorly on their intelligence, but also because they fear being perceived by others as incompetent.

Although there is evidence supporting both attributional and adaptationist theories of shame, some findings that appear to back one theory have been argued to support the other. To resolve this issue of data interpretation, Landers et al. (2024) conducted contrastive critical tests of the two theories. In a series of between-subject 2x2 factorial designs across both the United States and India, the authors experimentally manipulated the likely cost of being devalued by another person (low vs. high) as well as the reasons for the participant's action that resulted in costs imposed on that person (seemingly due to uncontrollable/stable vs. controllable/unstable causes). Consistent with the information threat theory, as the cost of the devaluative threat increased, participants in both countries reported more intense shame—regardless of whether they attributed their action that brought harm to uncontrollable/stable or controllable/unstable causes. In contrast, and contrary to attributional theory's predictions, attributions of the act to uncontrollable/stable (vs. controllable/unstable) causes did not result in more intense shame. Thus, data from the United States and India favored the information threat theory (the *inter*personal theory of shame) over attributional theory (the *intra*personal theory of shame). These findings indicate that the intrapersonal effects described in the emotion literature (e.g., the feeling that shame-inducing events are more uncontrollable than guilt-inducing events) are incidental or tributary to the interpersonal function of shame.

Rather than determining which emotions we experience (e.g., guilt or shame), the types of attributions identified by attributional theories—such as stability and controllability—may represent the conscious outputs of a cognitive system designed to respond to threats to social value (Sznycer et al., 2016). This adaptationist, interpersonal view of shame explains its context-sensitive nature: The same failure may lead to different behavioral outputs depending on whether it is more effective to acknowledge the failure and apologize, or to hide it, deflect attention elsewhere, threaten aggression, etc.

This interpersonal focus also helps explain why shame can lead to seemingly contradictory behaviors. Depending on the context, shame can motivate individuals to apologize and cooperate to repair social value, or resort to deception, deflection, or even aggression (Tangney et al., 1992; Elison et al., 2014; Fessler, 1999). For example, self-blame—often regarded as a hallmark of shame—may function as a signal of submission that discourages further attacks from others, or as a way to elicit forgiveness or sympathy (Gilbert, 2016). Conversely, in some situations, playing dumb or hiding shame may reduce the costs of public exposure.

Alternative Theories of Shame II: Norm-Based Theories

Another alternative theory suggests that shame plays a central role in enforcing conformity with social norms. Norm-based theories argue that pride and shame reward or punish behavior based on whether that behavior aligns with cultural expectations. For instance, an individual might feel shame after violating a norm against selfishness, while acting generously might elicit pride (Fessler, 1999; Bicchieri, 2005). This view emphasizes the role of shame in maintaining cooperation and social coordination by reinforcing shared norms.

However, norm-based theories face several limitations. The term “norm” is often vague or circular, encompassing a wide range of behaviors under a single conceptual umbrella. Definitions of norms—such as “normative standards of behavior that are enforced by informal social sanctions” (Fehr & Fischbacher, 2004, p. 63; see also Fessler, 2007)—may describe behavior but fail to explain the underlying causal mechanisms. When these mechanisms are understood, the label “norm” becomes largely superfluous.

Many social norms exist without a clear reason, driven mainly by the shared belief that most people adhere to them and expect others to do the same. This is often true for norms signaling coalitional membership. However, some norms carry independent motivational power. For instance, assisting close relatives is a cooperation norm rooted in kin selection, whereas avoiding sexual relations with close kin is a sexual norm stemming from selection against inbreeding depression (Charlesworth & Willis, 2009; Lieberman et al., 2007). Although cultural sanctions against incest exist, labeling these sanctions a "norm" obscures these more specific psychological and evolutionary explanations.

Additionally, grouping all elicitors of shame under the general umbrella of “norm violations” conceals important functional differences between them. The shame associated with stinginess differs meaningfully from that triggered by poor etiquette or low physical attractiveness (de Hooge et al., 2011; Leach & Cidam, 2015). A well-designed shame system should be capable of distinguishing among these different social threats and responding in contextually appropriate ways. For instance, the behavioral response to stinginess might involve efforts to repair one’s reputation for generosity, whereas the response to low attractiveness may focus on dieting, minimizing social exposure, seeking different social niches, etc. These distinctions highlight the adaptive flexibility of the shame system, suggesting that it is tuned to respond precisely to the nature of the specific social challenge at hand.

Furthermore, hiding, lying, threatening, and aggressing—common outputs of shame—can directly violate norms (Tangney, 1990; Elison et al., 2014; Sznycer et al., 2015), challenging the idea that shame is designed to promote normative behavior. Finally, although some norms vary across cultures, many of the same behaviors (e.g., selfishness, incompetence) elicit shame across societies, suggesting that shame is governed less by culturally specific norms and more by universal cognitive programs that adjust to local contexts (Sznycer et al., 2016; Sznycer et al., 2018; Leroux et al., 2023).

Concluding remarks

Shame is often conceptualized as a wretched, maladaptive emotion, or one that disproportionately occurs in certain cultural contexts, such as East Asian societies. However, when viewed through an adaptationist lens, shame reveals itself as a sophisticated, pan-human solution to the adaptive problem of social devaluation. While expressions of shame vary across situations, individuals, populations, and developmental and historical contexts, much of this variability reflects adaptive calibration to local circumstances and constraints, with the central theme being the minimization of the likelihood and cost of being socially devalued. In short, shame is neither a pathology nor a lesser substitute for guilt, but an elegantly engineered system designed to mitigate reputational risks and maintain access to social resources. Although

variance in shame expression exists across geographic locations and historical periods (Fessler, 2004), shame belongs to no single culture nor to individuals with maladaptive attributional styles; rather, it is an indelible part of human nature—a versatile, carefully crafted tool for navigating complex social landscapes.

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